

BERNERA NEWS

A Community Newsletter in association with **The Daily Ceilidh**

Welcome to Issue 24 of the Bernera News.

It's that time of year when the weather tricks us. A few warm sunny days try to convince us it is spring, and then the north wind blows, and with it the threat of snow, and we remember that we're not quite done with winter just yet!

The sunshine has been lovely though, and hopefully a time for most to get out and about a little more after what felt like a long winter. Some of us have ventured into our gardens, to start tidying up, or even to begin planting and planning for the year ahead. The smell of freshly picked daffodils on the kitchen table is a cheery reminder of what can survive and bloom, even after the harshest of conditions.

We, like daffodils, are stronger than we often realise, showing our true strength by re-emerging, no matter what life and the weather throws at us. This time of year is all about growth, new life, and repairing damage.

It's a time of positivity, and a chance to show the world exactly what we're made of. Storms can try their best to cause untold damage, but we will always bounce back, stronger than ever and glowing with enthusiasm for the year ahead.

MIANN NA MAIGHDINN-MARA



Mermaid Tales is back on BBC ALBA for a second series!

This time, Kate Macleod, The Hebridean Mermaid, takes us to some of the islands off the west coast of the Outer Hebrides on her journey south. Together with dad, Murray Macleod (Seatrek), we learn about the history, myths, stories and places most people won't get the opportunity to see in their lifetime. Tune in to explore islands such as Scarp, Taransay and Pabbay (Harris) - above and below the water.

From stories of murder and mythical waterhorses, to swimming with seals, and kayaking off some of the most spectacular beaches in Europe, this series is the ultimate adventure!

Airing weekly from Monday the 11th of April at 8.30pm on BBC ALBA and then on iPlayer for 30 days.

FUEL THEFTS

Due to a recent rise in the theft of fuel from domestic and commercial tanks, Highlands and Islands Police have offered the following tips:

Deter thieves from entering your property by installing and using lockable gates, and by maintaining boundaries and perimeter fencing. Plant shrubs or install fences to hide exposed domestic oil tanks from the eyes of opportunist thieves cruising the neighbourhood.

Consider fitting a locking cap to your tank.

Check tank oil levels regularly.

Where possible, install automatic movement sensor security lighting to cover your tank and the immediate surrounding area.

Consider fitting an alarm system that notifies you if fuel is being drained from the tank.

Be especially vigilant following a recent delivery of oil / diesel, and be aware that if thieves have already stolen fuel from your tank, they may return to steal any replacement you order.

People are encouraged to report any suspicious activity, or suspicious vehicles, to Police Scotland on 101. If you suspect a theft is in progress please call 999.

LESS SURVIVABLE CANCERS AWARENESS

This month, as part of our information sharing on the less survivable cancers, we will look at Liver cancer. Liver cancer is most common in people who already have liver disease, especially if they have cirrhosis (damage and scarring of the liver). This is why people with cirrhosis are offered regular checks for signs of liver cancer with ultrasound scans and blood tests every six months. It can, however, also develop in people with no history of liver disease. 80 - 90% of cases of hepatocellular carcinoma, the most common type of liver cancer, are linked to cirrhosis of the liver, which is most often caused by viral hepatitis, alcohol, and obesity.

Often there are no early symptoms of liver cancer because the liver is a very resilient organ that can continue to work well even when large parts of it are damaged. If you do notice symptoms, they may be similar to those seen in other liver conditions, in particular those of cirrhosis.

Symptoms can include:

A general feeling of poor health; Loss of appetite; Fatigue and weakness; Feeling sick (nausea) and vomiting; Loss of weight; Discomfort over the liver area (upper right section of the tummy); Itchy skin; Pale or grey poo; Dark urine; Loss of sex drive (libido).

Make sure you tell your doctor if you have any of the symptoms listed above. There are plenty of other causes for these symptoms, they do not necessarily mean that you have cancer.

If you have any of the following symptoms, seek medical help immediately:

Jaundice (yellowing of skin or eyes)

Swelling of the tummy (abdomen). This can be due to a build-up of fluid or the cancer itself

Vomiting blood

Tarry, black, sticky poo

As always, prevention, where possible, is far better than the cure. 9 out of 10 cases of liver disease are preventable. Read more about keeping your liver healthier below.

Liver Health and Alcohol

According to research, a quarter of us drink at levels that could put our health at risk. Regularly drinking more than the recommended amount over a long period can damage your liver. This can lead to alcohol-related liver disease (ARLD) and liver cancer. Every time we drink alcohol, the liver has to filter it in order to break it down and remove it from the body. Some liver cells die during this process, which is why the liver needs a break from alcohol to allow it to regenerate and make new cells. Drinking too much alcohol over a long period of time means the liver doesn't get a chance to recover. This can result in serious and permanent damage.

In order to reduce the risk of liver damage from alcohol:

Give your liver a break. Have at least 2 - 3 alcohol free days each week. Try to have them all in a row to give your liver time to regenerate and repair itself.

Men and women should drink no more than 14 units per week. As a guide there is one unit in a single measure (25ml) of most spirits, three units in a pint of 5.2% lager or cider, and 10 units in a bottle of 13.5% wine.

Read more about alcohol and the liver at www.britishlivertrust.org.uk

UIG CAFE

The cafe, based in the community centre in Uig, is looking to hire cafe assistants for the 2022 season (April - October). They are looking for enthusiastic, hard working people with good communication skills. Experience in the catering sector would be advantageous, but not essential. Hours are variable. Rate of pay is £10 per hour.

The Cafe will open Tuesday to Saturday 12 - 4pm each week, serving teas, coffees, light lunches and cakes. Opening hours may be extended as the season progresses.

For more information, or to request a job description, please email uigcafe@gmail.com, or call Roger on **07759 952618**.

POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLANDS - SPRING GARDENING



Is it spring though? Warm weather at the end of March? I have my doubts it will stay! Still, it is best to take advantage of a few warm rainless days to do some gardening. So, armed with a pair of loppers and a wood chipper, and suitably dressed, out I went. My spring jobs were cutting back overgrown escallonias, fuchsias, hawthorn and loads of wild raspberry canes, and then chip them all so I can put it all back as a mulch.

However, due to a walk with dogs I didn't finish and have another big area still to do.

Earlier this month I managed to get all my brassica seeds in and on the go, they'll soon be ready to prick out and pot on. We had a wonderful supply of cabbages and brussels sprouts right through the winter and so full of flavour, we are hoping to do the same this year. Plus the summer long potatoes were totally fabulous and maintained stock right into late Autumn. My brother in law has his earlies already in. Our ground is far too wet!

Our tomatoes were a bit of a failure last year, so my husband is sending away for tomato plants. I always think it is hard to choose the best tomato plants when all in a packet of what seems like millions all germinate at once. Then you are left with hundreds of tomato plants you can't give away! My first lot of Sweet Peas are now potted on in a trough. I got a load of cotoneaster plants in and they are now in my garden, along with some pretty purple crocus. Lots of spring bulbs up already, including one very brave white Tulip. The beautiful honey scented gorse has been bravely in flower all winter, though it is looking a bit battered from the winds we had. Well, we often get snow in April, so we will see.

Get out while you can, pull up the couch grass clogging up the flower beds, prune a few shrubs. It won't be long now before everything is growing furiously.

Penny Spinks
Hacklete



HISTORY QUIZ - ANSWERS

- | | |
|------------------------|---------------------------|
| 1. Mallard | 16. Sir James Matheson |
| 2. Francis Walshingham | 17. Tintagel |
| 3. Vikings | 18. Telephone |
| 4. Blackbeard | 19. Mercury |
| 5. Dictator | 20. Robert Baden Powell |
| 6. 1297 | 21. The Scout Association |
| 7. Golgotha | 22. Cuba |
| 8. Lord Carnarvon | 23. Louis XIV |
| 9. Abu Simbel | 24. First Folio |
| 10. Ramesses II | 25. 1948 |
| 11. Edinburgh | 26. Neolithic |
| 12. Constantinople | 27. Goddess Athena |
| 13. Sitting Bull | 28. Henry Sinclair |
| 14. Duke of Wellington | 29. Freemasons |
| 15. Operation Overlord | 30. Hadrian's Wall |

Colin Halliday
Kirkibost



TURSAN-LATHA



Nuair a bha mi a' fàs suas ann am baile beag, Boreland, cha robh e àbhaisteach a dhol air saor làithean thall-thairis, uill, a dh' innse na firinn, a dhol air saor làithean gu àite sam bith.

Còmhla ri mo charaidean, bhithinn a' coimhead air na dealbhan ann an "encyclopedia" na cloinne. An uair sin leigeadh sinn oirnn gun robh sinn air a bhith anns an Èiphit a dh' fhaicinn na Pioramaidean, neo anns a' Ghrèig a' tadhal air an Acropolis neo ann an ìomadh àite eile.

Bha an còmhnaidh cur-seachadan gu lèir ann. Gach samhradh nuair a thigeadh sìorcas gu àite faisg oirnn, deidheadh tri busaichean ann às a' bhaile, loma-lan inbhich is chloinne. Thachradh an aon rud aig àm na Nollaige nuair a dheidheadh sinn chun a' phantomaim.

Ach b' e na tursan bliadhna gu àiteachan ri taobh na mara, mar Portobello, Silloth neo Morecombe a b' fheàrr leinn.

Ma bu trice bha sinn fortanach agus bha sìde thioram, bhlàth is ghrianach ann. Bha e a' còrdadh ruinn a bhith air

an tràigh a' coimhead airson sligean, a' togail chaistealan-gainmhich agus a' cluich aig oir na mara.

Uaireannan, gheibheadh sinn tursan air bàtaichean-iomraidh agus bhitheadh cothrom againn marcachd air pònaidhean, neo asail, cuideachd.

A' bhliadhna a chaidh sinn gu Silloth, bha mi an dòchas gun tìgheadh mo mhàthair còmhla rium mar a b' àbhaist, ach cha b' urrainn dhi oir cha robh mo bhràthair, Harailt, ach beagan mhiosan a dh'aois.

An àite sin, shiubhail mi còmhla ri mo charaid, Mairead, agus a màthair.

Bha cuirm-chnuic aig a h-uile duine air an tràigh ach feasgar chaidh sinn gu taigh-bìdhe airson sùgh is cèic is reòiteag.

Nuair a chunnaic sinn amar snàmh chloinne anns a' ghàradh, ruith sinn ann cho luath sa b' urrainn dhuinn, agus thòisich sinn a' cluich anns an amar.

Gu fortanach, cha robh an t-uisge domhainn oir cha robh deise-snàmh aig duine sam bith. Bha tòrr spòrs againn ach, an uair sin, chuir màthair Mhairead roimhpe dealbhan a thogail.

Bha seòrsa de dh' eilean cloiche am meadhan an amair agus shreap mi fhìn is Mairead air, ach bha e cho sleamhainn agus, ann am priobadh na sùla, bha sinn nar laighe anns an uisge!

Maighdeannan-mhara? – Cha b'e - dìreach dithis nìghean bheaga, bog-fhluich!

Chroch na h-inbhich ar dreasaichean air geugan seilich agus cha b' fhada gus an robh iad air an tiormachadh anns a' ghrèin.

Abair brosnachadh! B' e sin an turas a b' fheàrr a-riamh!



Linne NicLeòid
Dun Innes



OUTER HEBRIDES COUNTY BIRD RECORDER

Hello! I'm Yvonne, bird recorder for the county for five years now. I've lived in the Outer Hebrides for 21 years, nine of those in Carloway, Lewis and then in Askernish, South Uist. I've been interested in birds since I was a child when I used to feed them in my parent's Shropshire garden and sketch the visitors.

Over the years I've worked here in the islands for the RSPB doing Corncrake surveys in Lewis and Harris, and for the Machair Life Project in Uist during its final year, carrying out wader surveys.

So, what does a county bird recorder do? At the most basic level this voluntary role is to collect and collate all the submitted bird records for the county. The vast majority of bird records are submitted by observers via the British Trust for Ornithology (BTO) BirdTrack website or app and these are then used by me to compile the annual bird report. I also receive records via email, spreadsheet, Facebook, telephone message and the increasingly popular eBird, all of which are then entered into BirdTrack so that they don't get lost. BirdTrack is used as the main database and archive for birds here.

OUTER HEBRIDES COUNTY BIRD RECORDER (CONTD)



How many records are submitted each year? As can be expected, with changes in technology the number is increasing each year. I'm currently compiling the 2018 bird report and for that year I received records from about 250 people, consisting of over 40,000 records, plus another 5,000 from eBird. As usual there were more records submitted for Uist & Barra than from Lewis and Harris, as can be seen from the map in the photograph.

One of the jobs of county recorder is to send information to a variety of bodies for their annual

report, one such is the Rare Breeding Birds Panel (RBBP) who collate data on all UK birds with less than 2,000 breeding pairs, more information on their work can be found at <https://rbbp.org.uk>

When submitting records during the breeding season it is always important to add information, if possible, about breeding status, i.e. pair displaying, on nest, feeding young. Using the BirdTrack app or website this information can easily be added. Amazingly enough Red-breasted Merganser is now an RBBP species. Submitting data to BirdTrack also helps the BTO analyse trends nationally.

BirdTrack: <https://bto.org/our-science/projects/birdtrack> (I am always happy to help and advise with BirdTrack usage).

As county recorder I am often the first point of contact for people visiting the islands, enquirers want to know the best places to go to see birds and how they can send me their records, so I have compiled information for both Lewis and Harris and for Uist, Benbecula and Barra which is available on request.

I sometimes think that the perception is that a local recorder is just interested in rare birds, this is far from the truth as it's the information about the more common birds that can help inform our knowledge of national trends, both good and bad. Though it is always good to receive the message "there's a very odd bird in my garden"! As regards birds, here in the islands we have four tiers – common birds not requiring a description, local rarities where a description and photo(s) are assessed by the Outer Hebrides Records Committee (OHRC), Scottish rarities assessed by Scottish Birds Records Committee (SBRC) and national rarities which are assessed by the British Birds Rarities Committee (BBRC). OHRC comprises five very experienced birders who look at local rarities and first records for the islands.

Visiting birders often don't appreciate the difference in the status and distribution of birds here e.g. Blue Tit – common in England but rarely seen here outwith Stornoway, but White-tailed Eagles often do a flyby. Ian Thompson has spent several years working on a fascinating resource to help with this issue, available online (with a small registration fee) at <https://status.outerhebrides-birdreports.org/> also available (without the photos) as an ebook on Amazon for £4.99.



During the breeding season I usually add a note to the Outer Hebrides Birds website to ask people not to publicise the whereabouts of nesting birds, and to be aware of what species need a special licence to approach or photograph during the breeding season. The Outer Hebrides Birds website <https://www.outerhebridesbirds.org.uk> is the main hub for the latest bird sightings for residents and visitors alike and lots more information, resources and photographs can be found there, feel free to register and add your own sightings.

Outer Hebrides Birds can also be found on Twitter at <https://twitter.com/HebridesBirds> feel free to tag @HebridesBirds in your tweets, we also have a Facebook page <https://www.facebook.com/outerhebridesbirds>

Enjoy birding and feel free to contact me with any questions or sightings
Yvonne Benting recorder@outerhebridesbirds.org.uk

GREAT BERNERA COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT TRUST

Kirkibost Pontoons



The Trust is now ready to take bookings for berths at the Pontoons. If you are interested in renting a berth (6 monthly or annually), or would like more information about rates etc., please get in touch with Callum Macaulay by email at dubhthob@gmail.com

Good News! Funding Secured for E-Bikes

As part of the ongoing Kirkibost Pier developments, we have now secured funding for six E-bikes and a storage shed in which to house them. The bikes will be available for locals and visitors to hire. This will be a great addition to the other developments at the pier area, meaning holiday makers using the camper van Hook Up points, those visiting by boat or staying at the Black Bay Recording Studios without transport will be able to bike around Bernera to sightsee and visit the Community

Centre's Museum and cafe.

The Trust is still awaiting an electricity connection (to recharge the bikes and for Hook Up Points), but it is hoped that the E-bikes will be available for this summer season. Funding was also secured for new Kettle Bells and static bike for the gymnasium at the Community Centre.

Second Part-Time Local Development Officer appointed



Joanna George moved to Lewis from Ardnamurchan in 2014 and has worked as a Support Worker, Therapeutic Employment Assistant, volunteering with Befriending Lewis and facilitating Trauma Healing workshops. Having worked in these fields, Joanna saw how important being involved in local community, and being supported by the community, is for people's mental well-being. When the job arose as Community Co-ordinator for the Trust, she was keen to use some of her previous skills and experience to contribute to their work to welcome newcomers and to inform and involve residents about the Trust's work and plans for future social and economic opportunities that affect us all. Following on from that job, Joanna is delighted to have now been offered a part time position as Community Development Officer, working alongside Nat Higginbottom and the team at the Trust to help realise more social and economic opportunities and inclusion for islanders.

Other Projects Currently in Development

Nat and Joanna are currently working in conjunction on two media projects. The first of these is a Welcome Information Pack. The idea behind this pack is to welcome newcomers to Bernera and give them a roadmap so to speak, of services in and around Bernera. The pack will also contain information of how to get involved in local community groups, clubs, and volunteering opportunities etc. (This information will also be available to existing residents and visitors). The second project in development is a new Trust website which will share additional information on many aspects of living on Bernera, from Community groups, nature, links to other local websites, services and more.

A CALL OUT to all tradesmen/women in the Bernera/Tir Mor area who offer a service, plumbers, joiners, builders, mobile hairdressers, fencers, taxi driver, driving lessons, support workers or home helps etc.. If you would like to give details of services you offer for inclusion in the Welcome Information Pack, please contact the Trust's Community Co-Ordinator, Joanna (via a message or phone call **(07771534048)** or email jo@greatbernera.org and let her know your name/business name, brief description of the service you offer and the best contact details and or web links.

Social Housing and Purchase of the Old Hatchery, Klrkibost

The Trust are committed to their work of bringing social and economic prosperity to Bernera, and while this has been made more difficult by the slow progress and on-going difficulties of purchasing Bernera Estate from the current owner, it has by no means put an end to future developments. The Trust has identified both an area of land and a property out with Estate ownership that could be developed to provide much needed

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Social Housing; and a space for small, local business development.

The two spaces currently being considered are an area of land in Breacleite (The Glebe) which is owned by the Free Church in Callanish, and The Old Hatchery at Kirkibost Pier.

While the purchase of The Glebe site is under negotiations, research is being made into the most suitable type of social housing for our community and The Trust are looking into small schemes such as those in rural areas of Mull, Harris and Eigg.

They are also asking members of the community to get in touch if they have a need for social housing. If you or a family member is elderly or disabled and are looking to downsize or move into a bungalow for health reasons, or if you, or a family member, or friend, cannot afford the current market prices but are looking to buy or rent a home here in the future, then please get in touch with Joanna (jo@greatbernera.org) so that we can register your interest and keep you informed about future developments.

The Trust are in the process of purchasing The Old Hatchery at Kirkibost pier area for use as a community owned Business Hub. This building has lain derelict for many years, and once the purchase is completed, it is intending to transform the existing building to bring economic benefit to Bernera. Based on a survey undertaken in 2021, the most popular propositions for the building were the creation of several small business units to incubate fledgling businesses; provision of larger units for use by more established businesses; a central, communal area which could contain shared services; and a communal library of things and workshop space for use by the community.



VISION

In the Bible, we read that 'where there is no vision, the people perish', Prov 29:18

The story is told of a group of people who had had a vision for a better future. Travelling to the northeast coast of America, several hundred years ago, they prioritised the establishment of building a town during their first year of occupation in this new and strange land, before going on to elect a government to run things the following year.

Interestingly, this government decided to build a 5-mile-long road westward, into the surrounding wilderness. A decision that led the people to rebel, and to seek to impeach the government, which they had only a matter of months before elected. "It's nothing but a waste of money!" "The money could be put to better use!" "Who's going to use it anyway!" they cried.

Ironically, it was the very same people, who had travelled thousands of miles to a place they had never seen, and at a great cost, financially, physically, mentally, and psychologically, who now, only a few years later, were unable to see the potential of even travelling 5 miles out of town. Their pioneering vision had vanished.

What vision do we have for our island of Bernera? A bridge has been erected that brings with it hope – a vision of families and young people being drawn and retained in our community. A vision of a re-invigorated community, despite the economic, social and employment challenges presently being faced.

Spiritually, if we possess a clear vision of what we may become, by God's grace in Christ, there will be no difficulty or challenge which cannot be overcome.

As Paul himself testified, 'I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me', Phil 4:13

Rev Hugh Maurice Stewart
Uig & Bernera



BERNERA BAKES... EASTER ROCKY ROAD ROULADE

INGREDIENTS:

6 medium free-range eggs, separated
100g caster sugar
35g cocoa powder, plus extra to dust
15g plain flour

For the filling:

4tbsp Biscoff spread or dulce de leche sauce
300g mixed Easter chocolates, roughly broken or chopped
75g roughly chopped toasted nuts
100g biscuits, broken into small chunks

For the topping:

90g milk chocolate, finely chopped

You will also need:

Electric mixer
 25cm x 33cm swiss roll tin
 baking paper



METHOD:

1. Heat the oven to 180°C/160°C fan/gas 4. Whisk egg yolks and sugar until creamy and thick. Mix the cocoa and flour in a small bowl, then sift onto the egg mixture and fold together gently.
2. Whisk the egg whites until just stiff. Mix 2 heaped tablespoons of the whisked whites into the cocoa/egg mixture to loosen. Add the remaining whisked whites to the mixture and very gently fold in until smooth and combined.
3. Add to the prepared tin and smooth the top. Bake for 12-15 minutes until springy. Remove and leave to cool for 5 minutes. Turn out onto a sheet of baking paper lightly dusted with cocoa powder. Peel away the lining paper and leave to cool for 5 minutes. Loosely roll up the sponge using the baking paper, then leave on the wire rack to cool.
4. Unroll the sponge and dot with the Biscoff/dulce de leche – roughly spread it out to make pockets of sauce. Whip the cream until it just holds its shape, then spread over the sponge in an even layer. Sprinkle over about two-thirds of the chocolates, nuts and biscuits, keeping the bigger chunks for the top. Roll up the sponge again using the baking paper to help.
5. For the topping, melt the chocolate. Allow to cool for 5-10 minutes (to thicken), then pour over the top of the roulade. Sprinkle over the extra chocolates, nuts and biscuits.

TIP:

For a more grown-up version, use brandy snaps or cantucci biscuits, salted caramel sauce and truffles (instead of mini eggs) in the filling/topping. Beat 2 tbsp hazelnut/Irish cream liqueur into the cream and drizzle with melted dark chocolate and a pinch of salt to finish.

Careen MacLennan
 Kirkibost

